

Women as Agents of Change in Bangladesh

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Structure of presentation

- Explain why look at women as agents of change
- Trends in Development and Women's Status
- Role played by the state and development agencies
- Historical overview of women's role
- Role of women's movement
- Challenges to women's gains

Why look at Women as Agents of Change?

- **Develop a nuanced understanding of the dramatic social changes and beyond stereotype**
  - Women are portrayed in a stereotypical manner in development and cultural studies literature on Bangladesh.
  - Deprived poor Bangladeshi women /or the deserving poor women as recipient of credit, social protection schemes, industrial workers in RMG
  - Women as symbols for depicting holders of Bengali culture
- **Learn about women's role and agency- herstory**


CHANGE IN WOMEN'S ROLE
AND STATUS

Bangladesh Context- Change in Women's Status

- **Women's condition and status has changed**
- **Bangladesh's Gender Development Index (GDI) rank: 134 (UNDP, 2018)**
- **Faster improvement after starting from lower points compared to countries in South Asia post 1971**
- **Health and education improved- the pace of improvement**
  - **Maternal mortality**: more than halved from 648 (1986) to 315 (2001) (World Bank, 2008); fertility declines from 7.4 in 1970s to 2.7 (2007)
  - **Education**: literacy rate: 49.5 for adult women ; gender parity in primary and secondary education; higher secondary stipend –female enrollment increased



Bangladesh Context

- **Legal Equality:**

  -Family laws (marriage, divorce, inheritance, custody) determined by religious personal laws (Islamic, Hindu, Anglican/ Catholic)– some reforms

  -Constitution guarantees equal rights in public sphere

- **Violence against women** :

-about 49 per cent are/ever married women experienced spousal physical violence (NIRPORT, 2007)

-Child marriage is high ; currently 53 (UNDP, 2018)



Bangladesh Context

- **Women in Politics**:
  -parliament (20.3%); local government 25% reservation;
  -women PM, women speaker, women ministers

- **Labor force/ Work: 33 percent for women**

Urban areas:

-formal sectors mostly RMG-about 2 million; informal sectors (domestic workers)

-government sector has quotas (15 per cent): primary education; health workers; nursing dominated by women

-wage gap narrowing for middle class women in professional jobs (still persists)

Rural Areas:

-Agriculture (home-based)

-public works for vulnerable women (divorced, abandoned etc)

-microcredit- 20.6 million borrowers-majority women (World Bank, 2008); SME growing





How did this change?

- In 1973, the GOB had no information on women and the FFYP focuses on women's role as mothers/ rehab for rape survivors of war
- Now development planning and policy targets women as service users, economic agents, CSO actors, policy makers
- **Actors:**

  -Government through policies, actions (family planning / health; education);

  NGOs: service delivery and rights (non formal education; credit; legal aid);

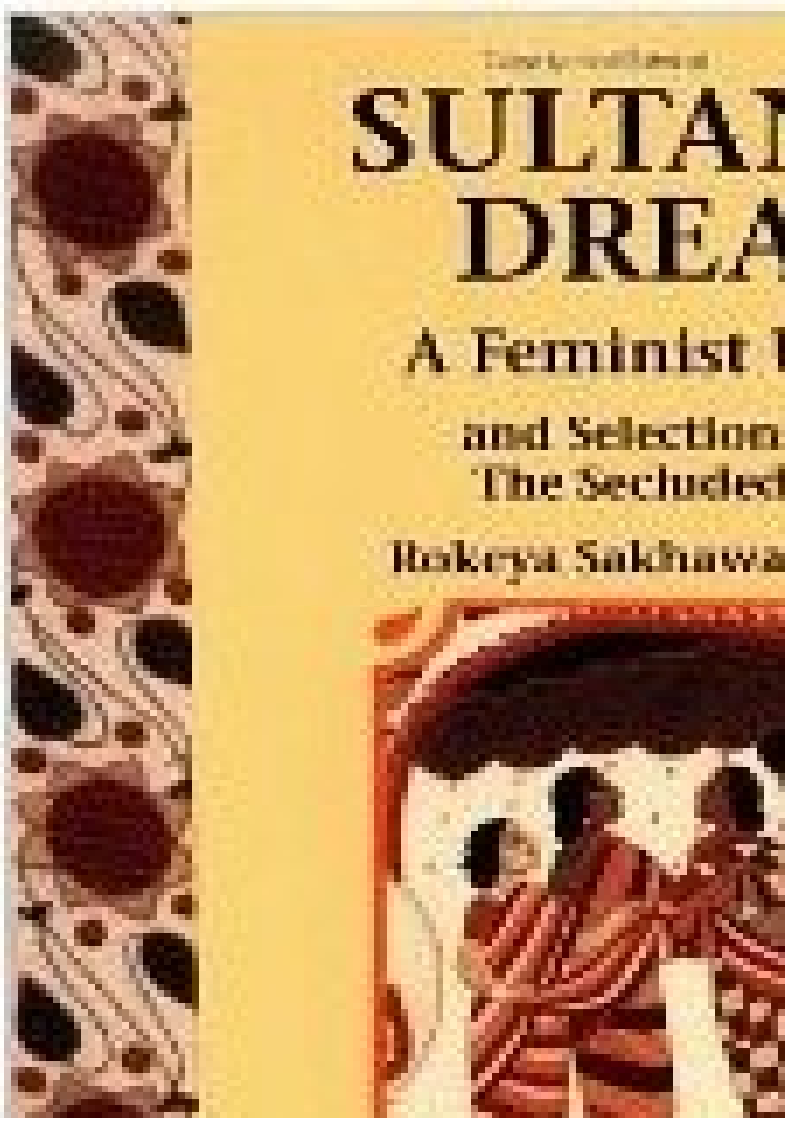
  -donor: funding creative initiatives (policy networks/ HR awareness raising, anti VAW; shelter, trafficking)
- ***Mostly the women who did the heavy lifting!***

ROLE OF WOMEN

Women as Agents of Change

- Women have a long history in participating in anti colonial struggles/social welfare/ economic entrepreneurship
  - Rokeya—educationist for Muslim women, feminist inspiration (late 1800s to 1930s)
  - Pritilata (1920/ 30s)/ Ila Mitra (1950s)/ Kumudini Hajong (1950s) fought colonial powers
  - Leela Nag (1920/30s)/ Shausmnnahar Mahmud (1940/50s/60s)– social welfare/ disaster relief
  - Sufia Kamal- poet and established BMP, the largest women's organization with 150,000 members at the grassroots (1940s to 1990s)




SULTA
DREA
A Feminist
and Selection
The Secluded
Rokeya Sakhawa



Women's Agency (ability to do and act)

- Women credit borrowers– many of whom successful entrepreneurs in pulling their families out of poverty (joint decision making/ space)—handle cash, meet outside; repay back in time
- RMG worker– learned to negotiate at home (marriage /control over income/ etc; but also right to be in public spaces)—keep the industry running
- Women health worker– behind family planning's success
- Professional women (doctors/lawyers/academics)/ women in state service




SANSI











COLLECTIVE STRUGGLES

Women's Movement and Activism

- Most vibrant ('tick on the back of the elephant with a loud voice')!
- **Types of women's organizations:**

-a) activist (mass based; smaller; professional organizations)

-b) policy and research advocacy organizations;

-c) women's NGOs; social movement oriented NGOs

- Membership based; local/national; degree of formalization may vary


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নারী
নির্যাতন
বন্ধ
করবো

Issues Tackled by Women's Movement Over the years

- **1970s**: rehabilitation, development initiatives
- **1980s**: violence against women (dowry); family courts; political participation; gender mainstreaming; personal law; population policy; Islam as state religion
- **1990s**: fatwa (religious edict); state violence (custodial rape); uniform family code; mainstreaming gender/gender budgets; acid violence; shrimp farming; sexual harassment in educational institutions; CHT, minority rights; trafficking; sex worker's movements
- **2000 onward**: migration; minority rights; domestic violence; sexual harassment, national women's development policy



Women in Other Social Movement

- **Women in national movements**

-women question; symbols of protest; later on in war (1971)

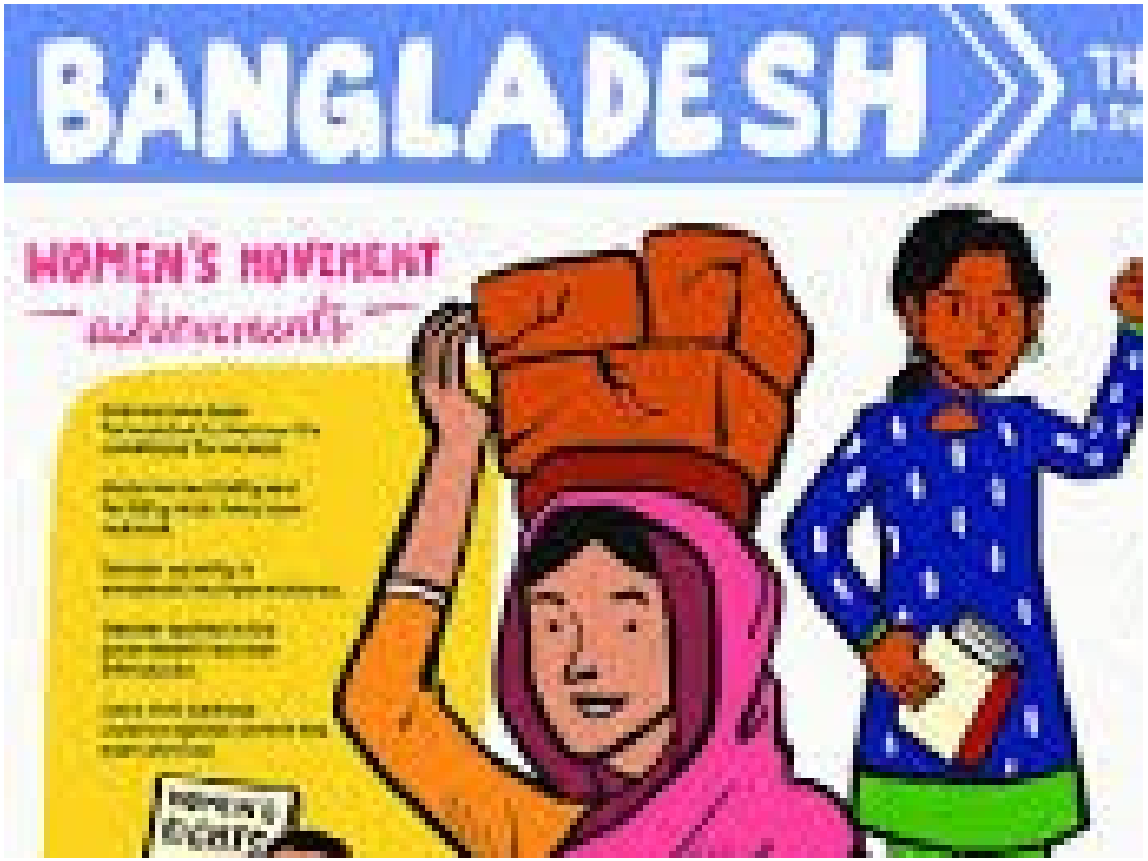
- **Women's collective action**

- Peasant movements (tebhaga);
- anti shrimp farming;
- women and use of the 'commons' (mulberry trees; aquaculture);
- land movements

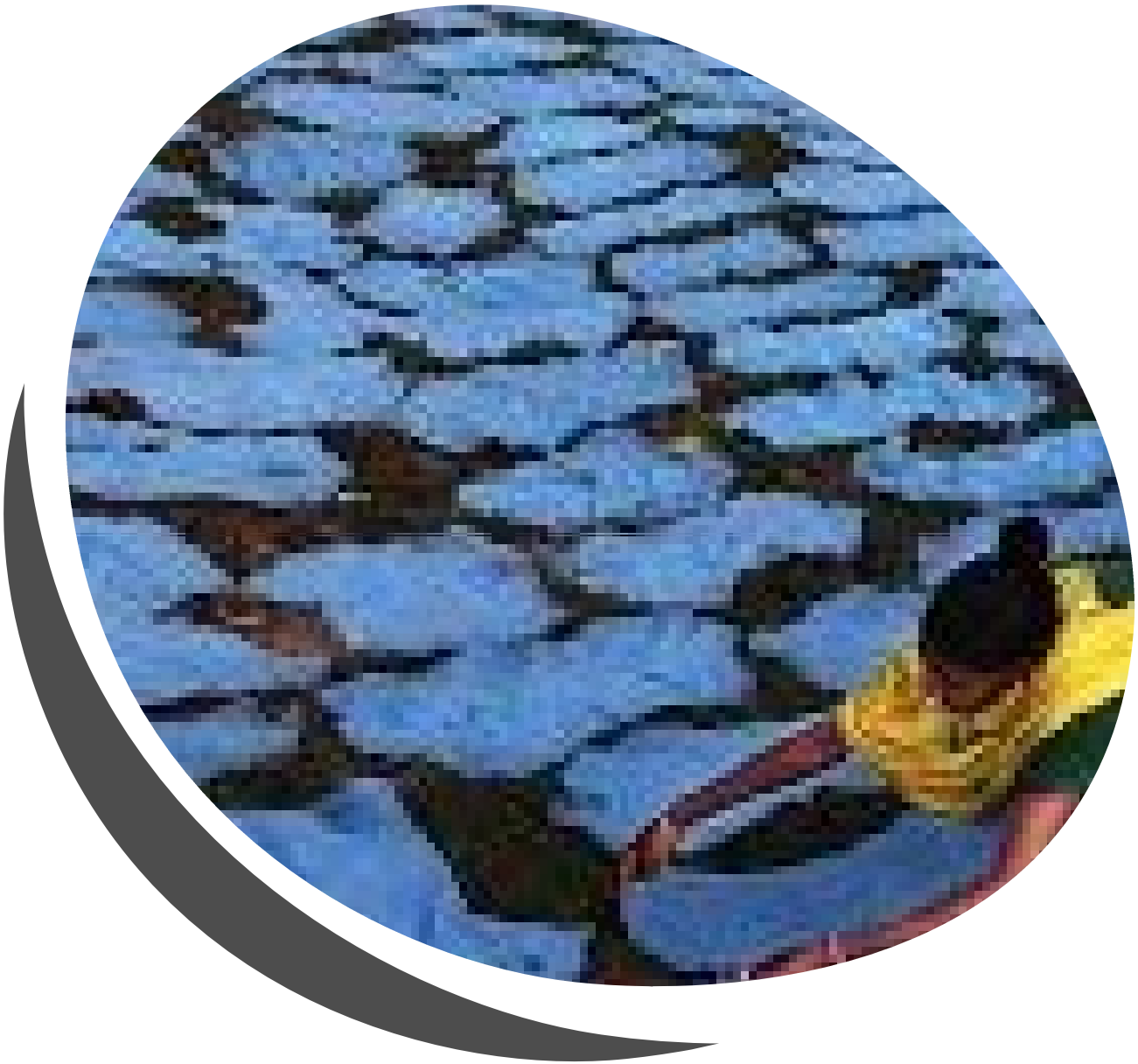
- **Women in minority struggles**

-CHT (Kalpana Chakma); Hill Women's Federation

- Women in labor movement/ migration movement (BOMSA)


BANGLADESH
WOMEN'S MOVEMENT
achievements


CHALLENGES
TO GAINS





Development Challenges/ Wider Challenges for Women's Agency

- Accessing global policy spaces on trade/labor(RMG/ shrimps/ migration)—who speaks for women in spaces that are not gender friendly? What is happening post Rana plaza?
- Women's double burden the care economy work—recognizing that in policy
- VAW in public space—how to contain/ change values/ and implementation of domestic violence act, sexual harassment laws
- Climate change (work opportunities/ impact on reproductive burden/ time--water; natural disasters affecting families)
- Changing biased family laws
- Sticky norms and beaviour change
- COVID-19

CONCLUSIONS

- Herstory: Women at all levels have engaged in different ways
- Significant gains made social development; discrimination exists
  - State, development actors played a key role
- Women's movement's was critical in ensuring rights, policy/ law change; focus on non-traditional issues
- New challenges linked to global issues and norm change


gettyimages
Zakir Hossain C

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Sources Used

For visual aids:

- Tales of Freedom, directed by Dr. Mirza Hassan (available on Youtube) These are the youtube links-- its in three parts.

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JN9JErdK7As

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9QWkgsH2R0Q
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=32j7z6vf7Ok